

Pennsylvania Rail Trails – Pittsburgh Region

A Nationwide Network of Recreation Trails from Former Rail Lines

By Albrecht Powell, About.com Guide

Did you know that you can hop on a bike in Pittsburgh, and, depending on your legs, ride motor-free to Harrisburg and Washington DC. Sound far-fetched? That day is actually closer than you may think!

The nonprofit organization Rails to Trails Conservancy has been working since 1986 to create a nationwide network of public trails from former rail lines. Currently, they have helped preserve nearly 11,000 miles of abandoned rail lines, and converted them into 1,027 trails across 49 states. They are currently working to develop another 18,000 miles of trails. Pennsylvania leads the nation in rail-trail development, opening its 100th trail in June 1999, the first state to reach this remarkable plateau.

Rail-Trails are paths created from abandoned railroad corridors. Flat, or following a gentle grade (generally 1-3%), they traverse urban, suburban and rural America. They are ideal for many varied recreation uses such as bicycling, walking, running, skating, cross-country skiing, horseback riding, and wheelchair recreation.

These Rail-Trails, in addition to being excellent recreational opportunities generate significant economic benefit to communities through which the trails run. In recent studies, it was estimated that as much as \$1.25 million can be generated annually for the towns through which a trail passes.

Rail-trails bring historic structures, such as train stations, bridges, tunnels, mills, factories and canals back to life for all to enjoy. These structures preserve an important piece of history and enhance the trail experience.

It is a complex process to convert a railroad corridor into a recreation trail. After all possibilities for continued rail service have been exhausted, a rail corridor may be declared abandoned. If a rail line is declared truly abandoned, the corridor will likely not be kept intact as many different people and organizations may hold claim to the land. In the late 1800's and early 1900's when the United States had the most extensive railroad transportation network in the world, over 300,000 miles of track spanned the nation – a network six times larger than today's interstate highway system! To accomplish this, land was either purchased or leased from individuals, states, communities, and the federal government. As the railroads continue to diminish, more than 2,000 miles of track every year are no longer used by the railroad industry, and, if abandoned, are 'up for grabs' by these former landowners.

Based on a law passed in 1983, rails that are being abandoned can be 'railbanked' or set aside for future use while being used as trails in the interim. This law essentially preempts rail corridor abandonment, keeping the corridors intact for trail use.

Once a trail has been 'railbanked,' the process of conversion to trails can begin. This usually involves the railroad pulling up the old track and ties for salvage, the old rail bed is re-graded, and then a surface covering of crushed limestone, gravel, woodchips, or asphalt is applied. Bridges and tunnels are

renovated to ensure safety. In many cases new bridges have to be constructed as the old railroad bridges no longer exist, or are too unsafe. The cost to convert a trail (mostly in resurfacing) can run between \$10,000-\$40,000 per mile, which is significantly cheaper than other forms of recreation (e.g. playgrounds). These trails are then managed by local organizations, usually staffed by volunteers, and are being used by over 100 million people each year!

In Pennsylvania alone, there are 105 existing trails covering 867 miles, with another 102 trails covering 1112 miles under development. Western Pennsylvania has an unbelievable 200+ miles of operating trails. Some of the most popular are those managed by the Allegheny Trail Alliance, which is developing a continuous trail 206 miles long (of which 116 miles is completed) to connect Pittsburgh to Cumberland MD. The trail then will connect to the C&O Canal Towpath which winds another 185 miles into Washington DC. In another year or two, it will be possible to ride about 370 miles traffic-free from Pittsburgh to Washington DC. Today, the trip can be done with only about 60 miles of detours on roadways.

The trails around Pittsburgh are mostly surfaced with crushed limestone. This makes it a bit bumpy for a road bike (skinny tires), but not impossible. Most people ride a 'hybrid' or a typical mountain bike. The trails are clean, wide open and safe. They are also very peaceful and wend through some very rural stretches where one can often go for miles without seeing another living person. Other times, a trail may pass through small towns, where the remnants of an old train station is all that is left of a town's once prosperous days.

One of the biggest benefits of these trails to recreational users comes from a scientific law of train travel – trains do not like hills. As such, none of these rails have very large hills, other than gradual slight grades. This makes for very enjoyable bike riding.

There are 6 major trails in Western Pennsylvania:

Montour Trail

The Montour Railroad was built in 1877 and eventually linked the Pittsburgh and Lake Erie Railroad with over 30 area coal mines. When fully completed, the Montour Trail's 55 miles will connect the Ohio and Monongahela Rivers, crossing numerous highways and creeks on a variety of bridges, including one almost 1,000 feet long, and three tunnels. The paved section running through Peter's Township and the section from Robinson Township up to the river are especially popular.

The Montour Trail is a multi-use non-motorized recreational rail-trail near Pittsburgh, PA, that will ultimately extend 46 miles from Moon Township near Coraopolis to Clairton. Currently, multiple sections of the trail totaling over 40 miles are completed. New sections are being added each year.

The Montour trail is paved with a smooth surface of crushed limestone, which makes it ideal for all forms of non-motorized use: bicycling, walking, running and cross-country skiing. In certain sections, horseback riding is also permitted, but not on the improved trail surface.

One section of the Montour trail within Peters Township, called The Arrowhead Trail, is a paved surface, suitable for roller blading as well as cycling, walking and running. This portion of the Montour Trail is owned and maintained by Peters Township.

The Montour Railroad was built in 1877 and eventually linked the Pittsburgh and Lake Erie Railroad with over 30 area coal mines. Forming a semi-circle around the western and southern sections of the city of Pittsburgh, the Montour also connected with other railroads, including the Pennsylvania, the Pittsburgh and West Virginia, the Baltimore and Ohio, and the Union. When completed, the Montour Trail's 55 miles will connect the Ohio and Monongahela Rivers, crossing numerous highways and creeks on a variety of bridges, including one almost 1,000 feet long, and three tunnels.

Portable toilets are located approximately every 2-4 miles along the Montour Trail from May through October only. Water fountains can be found every 2 mile or so along the more heavily trafficked sections of the Montour Trail (such as Robinson) and as far apart as 6-7 miles along the more rural sections.

In McDonald, near the McDonald Trestle, a trail connector leads off from the Montour Trail to connect walkers, runners and cyclists with the nearby Panhandle Trail. Follow the connector trail down to 980 and then cross the street to the parking lot to continue following the connector up to the Panhandle Trail. Left on the Panhandle Trail will take you towards Sturgeon, Oakdale and the trail end near Walker's Mill. Right on the Panhandle Trail will take you through Burgettstown and several miles into West Virginia.

Visit the [Montour Trail Web site](#) for up-to-date information on access points, parking, amenities (such as water and restrooms), as well as suggested detours around uncompleted sections.

Panhandle Trail

This nice, flat trail is right down the road from me, and stretches for 29 miles from Walkers Mill near Carnegie, PA, to just outside of Weirton, WV. There are a few rougher sections as you approach the PA border with West Virginia, but the entire trail is fully open and walkable/rideable! It also connects directly with the Montour trail in McDonald.

The 100th successful rail-trail project in Pennsylvania, the Panhandle Trail stretches for 29 miles from Walkers Mill near Carnegie, PA, to just outside of Weirton, WV.

The entire length of the Panhandle Trail is open from Walkers Mill near Carnegie, PA, to just outside of Weirton, WV, most of it paved with a smooth surface of crushed limestone. The nearly 8-mile section of the trail between Burgettstown and the PA/WV state line is a bit rougher than the rest of the trail with more packed dirt and loose gravel sections. The crushed limestone section resumes at the WV state line.

Port-o-johns are situated every few miles along the Panhandle Trail. Permanent restrooms (and a water fountain!) are available at mile 5.75 in Sturgeon, and can also be found at several small town convenience stores located close to the trail. Benches and picnic tables along the trail provide

opportunity for resting, as well as enjoying scenic views. A picnic table and old train marker from the P.C.C. & L.R.R. offer an especially welcome rest stop at the PA/WV state line.

At mile 8.62 a trail connector leads off from the Panhandle Trail to connect walkers, runners and cyclists with the nearby [Montour Trail](#). Follow the connector trail into the parking lot for the Montour Trail, then across 980 and up to the trail. Left on the Montour Trail will take you across the McDonald Trestle towards Cecil (Washington County), while right takes you north on the Montour Trail towards Quicksilver, Imperial, Robinson Township and Coraopolis.

Visit the [Collier Friends of the Panhandle Trail](#) Web site for directions to trail parking and entrances, a downloadable PDF trail map, and mileage charts with points of interest and amenities.

Steel Heritage Trail

This trail, when fully completed, will connect the Montour Trail, the Three Rivers Heritage Trail and the Youghiogheny River Trail, running along the Monongahela River from Sandcastle Park, through Homestead, past Kennywood Amusement Park, across the Monongahela and then south through McKeesport and Glassport to Clairton, PA. The Steel Heritage Trail forms a crucial link in the 325 mile trail network from Pittsburgh to Washington, D.C.

Three Rivers Heritage Trail

This trail links some of the most dynamic, geographic, and historical features of the City of Pittsburgh. It begins at Washington's Landing, a 42 acre island in the Allegheny River. It then travels down the Allegheny to the Ohio River, past Roberto Clemente Park and the Carnegie Science Center. From there it crosses the Ohio and proceeds up the Monongahela River past Station Square and Southside Riverfront Park. The downtown trails along the North Shore and the South Side, as well as the Eliza Furnace Trail, are all part of the Three Rivers trail.

Running for a nearly complete 21 miles along the rivers of downtown Pittsburgh, the Three Rivers Heritage Trail system offers public trail access for cyclists, walkers, runners, and in some places, rollerbladers. Even cross country skiing when we have enough snow!

The Three Rivers Heritage Trail which evolved from five separate trails surrounding downtown Pittsburgh, runs along both sides of the Allegheny and Monongahela Rivers, crisscrossing bridges into downtown, and continuing down the Ohio River. Some sections are paved with asphalt or concrete, and others with crushed limestone.

It's a bit confusing for new visitors, but the Three Rivers Heritage Trail actually has nine different named sections - and these names are generally what you'll find in use by the locals. The most popular portions run right along Pittsburgh's rivers:

- **North Shore Trail** - The North Shore section of the Three River Heritage Trail extends along the northern shore of the Allegheny River for 8 miles from Brunot Island, past downtown Pittsburgh to Millvale.

- **Southside Trail** - This mostly paved trail section (with crushed gravel alongside for joggers) runs for 6.6 miles out and back along the south side of the Monongahela River from the Southside Riverfront Park on its western end. Passes the practice field for the Pittsburgh Steelers and Panthers.
- **Eliza Furnace Trail** - This four mile section of paved trail begins at the parking lot on Swineburn Street and follows the north side of the Monongahela River. Its eastern end connects to the Panther Hollow Trail leading into Schenley Park, and its western end will eventually connect into Point State Park. Paved and well-used, but with a lot of traffic noise!
- **Pittsburgh Riverwalk** - At Station Square, the Southside Trail section connects with the short, 1.5 mile Pittsburgh Riverwalk. Great pedestrian access into the Station Square shops and beautiful views of the Golden Triangle!

The Hot Metal Bridge, which was once used to carry iron by rail from the Eliza furnaces to the Pittsburgh Southside, is now a pedestrian-only connection bridge connecting the Eliza Furnace Trail to the Southside and Steel Valley Trails.

The Three Rivers Heritage Trail offers some parking and restroom options, as well as historic and interpretive signs, river views, kayak and canoe launching points - even free bike rentals!

Check out the [interactive Three Rivers Heritage Trail map](#) created by [Friends of the Riverfront](#). It lists trailside amenities, as well as "points of interest" close to where the Heritage Trail runs.

Youghiogheny River Trail - North

Built in 1883, the Pittsburgh, McKeesport, and Youghiogheny hauled coal and coke from the rich Connellsville District to the steel mills of Pittsburgh. This trail winds for 40 miles from the mouth of the Yough River southward to Connellsville and is especially suited to long-distance leisure trips, since the rise in elevation is no more than 100 feet for the entire trail.

Youghiogheny River Trail - South

This 28 mile segment of the Youghiogheny River Trail follows the abandoned Western Maryland Railroad, which was built in 1912. The trail meanders from Confluence to Connellsville along the scenic Yough river and through Ohiopyle State Park.

No more excuses - get out and enjoy one of the Pittsburgh area's great rail trails today!

Source:

http://pittsburgh.about.com/od/biking/a/rail_trails_2.htm

http://pittsburgh.about.com/od/biking/p/montour_trail.htm

http://pittsburgh.about.com/od/biking/p/panhandle_trail.htm